

The 5 Fatal Mistakes of Enterprise AI Strategy

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Five conversations from the last month



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Copying someone else's AI strategy



A LEADING INSURER

“BNY built their own AI platform.
So we should too, right?”

Where does this business win?

BNY

A bank serving financial institutions

Custody, settlement, payments

Scale and reliability

Banking infrastructure

An insurer

A business selecting and serving risk

Underwriting and pricing

Distribution and retention

Claims and customer service

Put your best builders where the business competes

Where does each business win with AI?

BNY - Ops & Infra

- Resolve settlement exceptions
- Connect transaction records
- Improve reliable processing
- AI-native financial infrastructure

An insurer - Risk & Service

- Improve underwriting decisions
- Connect risk and policy context
- Quote better business faster
- Better customer service

Illustrative priorities tied to each business model

What will still be differentiated when you launch?

Earlier investment



Your next investment

2024 Eliza

2025 Eliza 2.0

Advantage at launch

Next market review

Which of these businesses give you an advantage?

Different decision to buy, partner or build at each layer

Specialist apps

General apps

Harness / agent runtime

Models

Serving / compute / chips

Data centers

Power generation

Land / permits / community relations

Before you fund another platform

Advantage

Why own
this layer?

Timing

Will the edge
still exist at
launch?

Upkeep

What will we
need to
maintain?

Reassessment

When should
we replace it?

Set a review date when you approve the investment

Promising value
without a plan
to realize and
measure it



“Why do AI initiatives fail?”

Where does the \$50M come from?

\$50M

Proposed benefit

Work changes

A faster, better workflow

Business acts

Redeploy capacity or
avoid an expense

Value appears

More output, revenue
or lower spending

Before you fund it, answer four questions

Baseline

What happens today?

Change

What work will change?

Owner

Who runs the program?

Evidence

How will we measure value?

Name a program owner for adoption and value reporting

Insisting on doing everything yourself



A BANK CIO

“We never choose
one provider.”

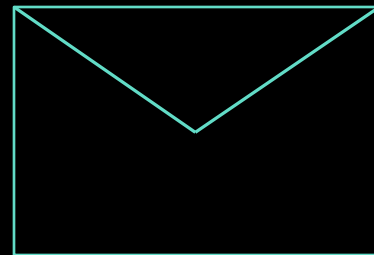
Later: “Why aren’t you doing more for us?”

This is the next technology upgrade cycle

What can we learn from previous cycles?

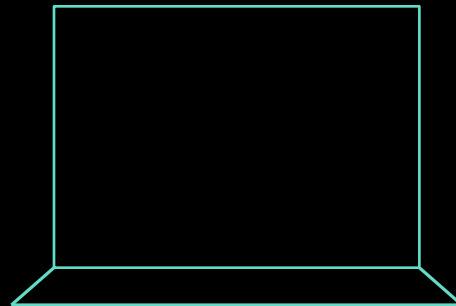
What would you say?

“I need Gmail
and Google Drive”



What would you say?

“I prefer a MacBook”



What would you say?

“Can I choose
my coding agent?”



What should be standard?

Employee workspace

A primary collaboration system

Specialist tools

Approved choice based on results

Internal automation

A supported platform by default

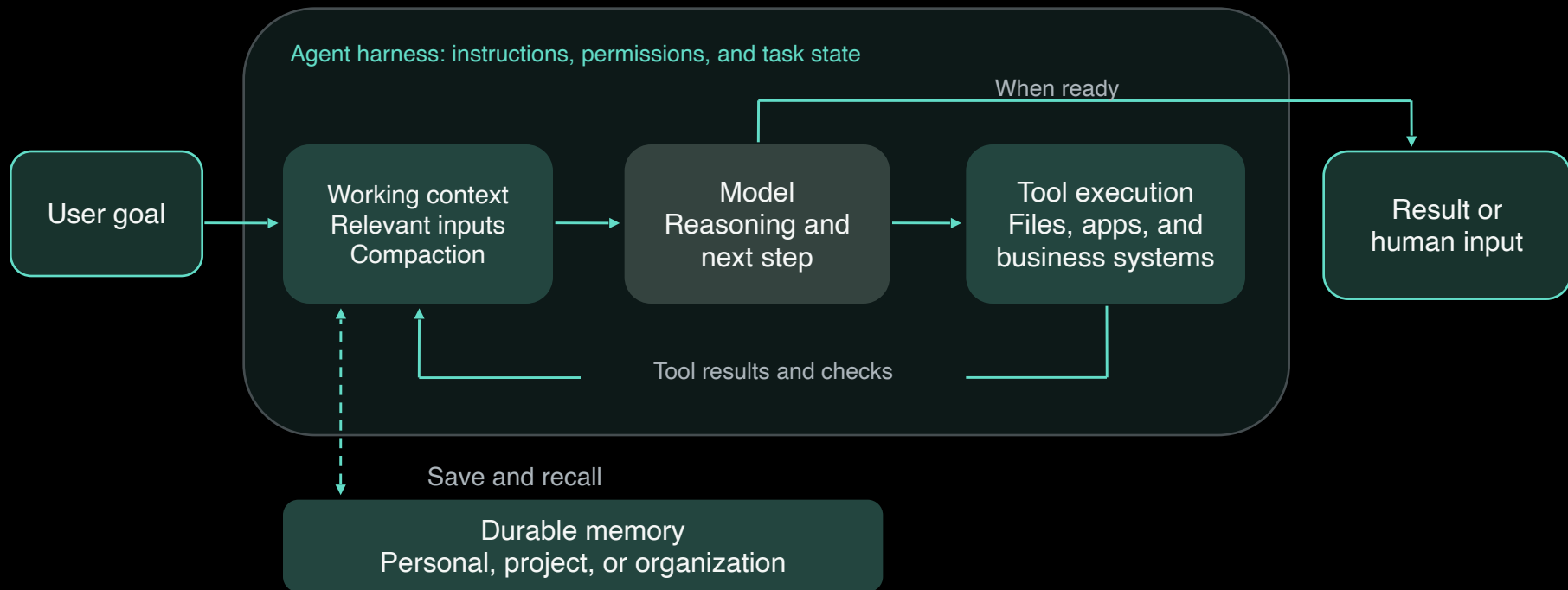
Customer products

Build where you differentiate

Security, portability and an exit plan apply across the stack

The agent harness

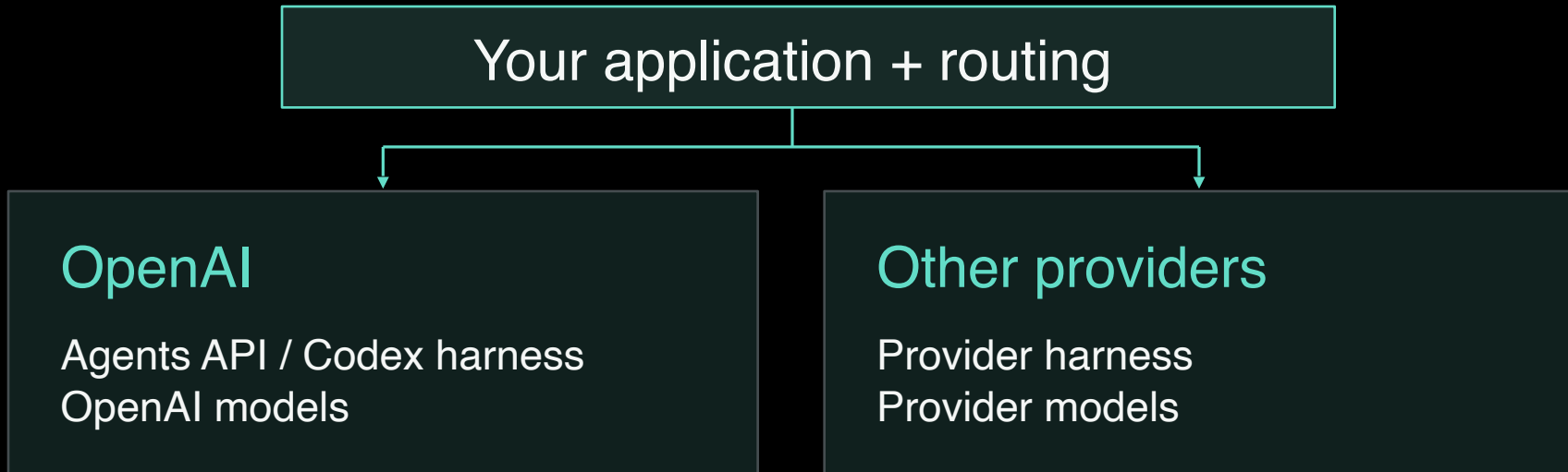
Software around the model that manages context, tool execution, and continuity.



Context, tool calls and recovery affect quality, latency and cost

KEEP YOUR OPTIONS

Put the routing layer above the harness



Compare complete systems on your workflows

What makes a good partnership?

Your commitment

- Clear priorities and ownership
- Access to working teams
- A willingness to learn and test

Partner commitment

- Product and deployment expertise
- Joint problem-solving
- Accountability for follow-through

A primary partner can coexist with tested alternatives

We 3x'd product,
why hasn't revenue
tripled?



A private equity firm

Deployed internal FDEs across 60 portfolio companies

3x

product throughput

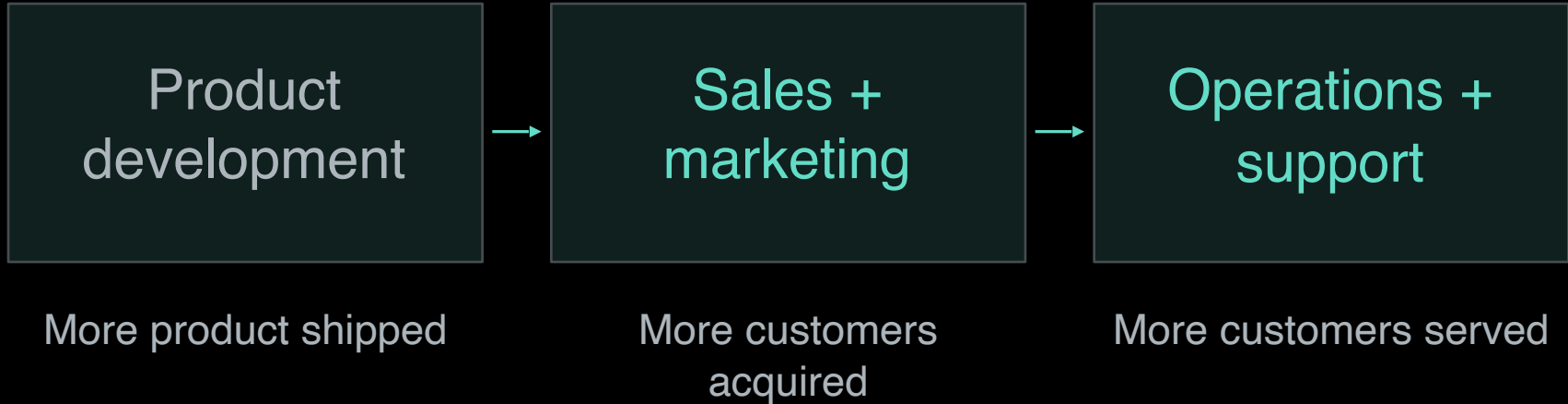
A private equity firm

Deployed internal FDEs across 60 portfolio companies

No comparable lift

in revenue or growth

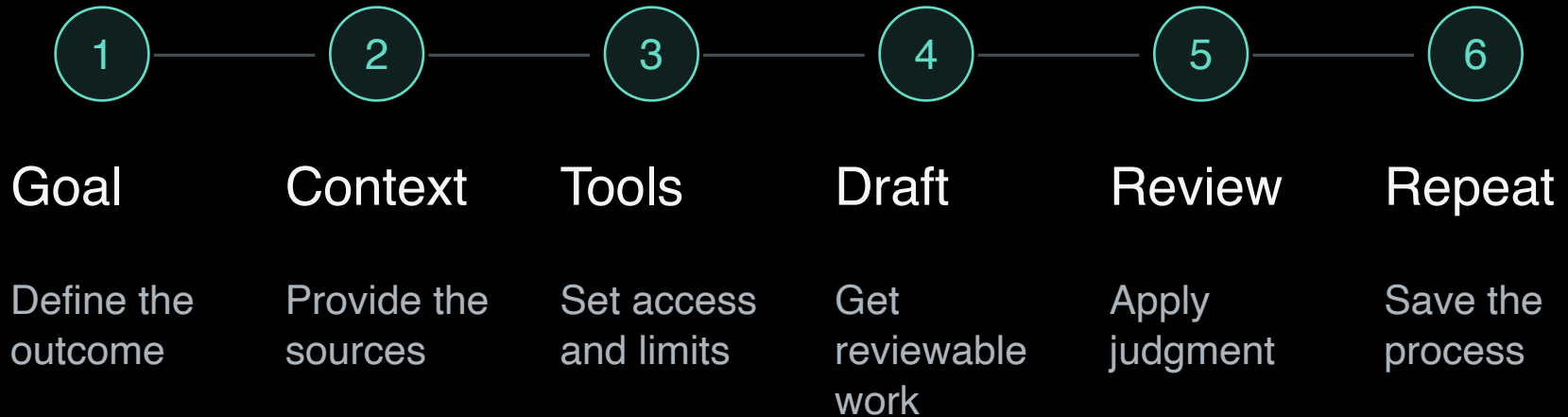
What becomes the next constraint?



Remove one constraint and watch for the next

A SKILL TO TEACH EVERY EMPLOYEE

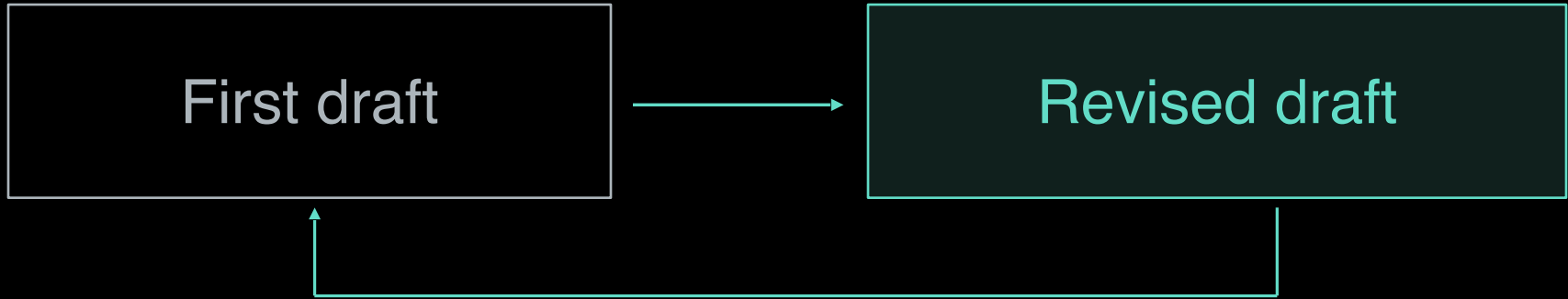
Delegation is an executive skill



The person delegating remains accountable

Treat the first result as a draft

Your feedback



Give specific feedback and iterate

How does the rest of the company get there?

Time to learn

Practice during
the workday

Team champions

Learn from colleagues
getting strong results

AI-first mindset

Encourage AI in
everyday work

Manager follow-through

Change the workflow
and measure the result

Make enablement part of the program owner's job

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Making every team wait for your platform



AN EXECUTIVE LUNCH

“We have a governed platform
for all AI use cases.”

Your platform's backlog becomes the business's backlog

Team + model
ready



Waiting for
platform support



Business
outcome

Make company context usable

Start with a valuable workflow and reuse what works



Identity / Source permissions / Approved actions / Evaluation

Give strategic teams an approved way to move faster

SHARED CONTROLS

Standard platform

Broad adoption
Supported defaults

Strategic teams

Named owner + outcome
Implementation choice

Security / Data access / Evaluation / Release and support ownership

Five decisions to revisit

- | | | |
|---|-------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 1 | Copying a peer | Start with where your business wins |
| 2 | ROI without a plan | Name the change, owner and measure |
| 3 | Going it alone | Build on proven systems and partners |
| 4 | Stopping at engineering | Find the next business constraint |
| 5 | One mandatory platform | Approve more than one delivery path |

Where would you invest differently today?

Invest while it can still win you share

2023–25

Build capability

Models, automation
and assistants

2026–27

Business growth

New products
and market share

2028–29

Table stakes

My forecast:
competitive necessity

The help I'm looking for:

Does this approach resonate?

What other mistakes are you seeing?

Are you interested in engaging on these topics?

Thank you!



Joe Beutler

